

How to Build a UI (SOP)

Purpose

Create production-quality interfaces by separating design from implementation. The design team defines the product. Codex faithfully implements it.

The UI Implementation Package

1. Reference Mockup (The Vision)

Create the exact screen you want. Iterate until it is approved.

2. Engineering Specification (The Blueprint)

Document layout, spacing, typography, colors, component sizes, responsive behavior, interaction rules, and design tokens. Leave nothing open to interpretation.

3. Acceptance Checklist (Definition of Done)

Create objective pass/fail requirements that define when implementation is complete.

4. Codex Implementation Prompt

Reference the mockup, specification, and checklist. Treat the mockup as the source of truth, not inspiration.

5. Design Rationale (Recommended)

Record the purpose of the screen, its primary task, visual hierarchy, and why major design decisions were made.

Recommended Folder Structure

```
design-reference/  
  dashboard/  
    reference.png  
    spec.md  
    checklist.md  
    rationale.md  
    codex-prompt.md
```

Repeat this structure for every major screen.

Operating Rules

- Finish the design before implementation.
- Codex implements; it does not invent the UI.
- Treat mockups as specifications.
- Every screen has one dominant task and one primary action.
- Preserve functionality while refining presentation.
- Build reusable components and design tokens.

Implementation Loop

Design → Approve → Specify → Checklist → Codex Build → Review Against Checklist → Correct Deviations → Ship

Definition of Success

Every implemented screen matches its approved reference, satisfies every checklist item, preserves all workflows, and feels like part of one cohesive product.